

Worship in Spirit and in Truth

John 1 begins:

| In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

Before anything in the natural universe had a beginning, the mighty Logos, the second Person of the Godhead, existed. Genesis says God created the heavens and earth; John distinguishes the roles the Persons took in creation.

When you say, "I love You, God," you address the three Persons who are one God. "I love You, Father" addresses the One Israel knew as mighty Jehovah. "I love You, Jesus" addresses the glorified humanity and eternal deity of the Logos. It is also right to say, "I love You, Holy Spirit," though His ministry will always direct glory to Jesus rather than Himself.

The Father planned creation. The Son made all things:

| All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made.

John later identifies Him:

| He was in the world, and the world was made by him, and the world knew him not.

All things, including thrones, dominions, principalities, powers, angels, men, and even the atoms of this chair, consist by Him, for Him, and through Him. The Holy Spirit is the Regenerator who moved in creation and later regenerated us.

Father and Son are descriptions God adopted so that human minds could understand aspects of Him. Christ's humanity had a beginning; His deity did not. We may become brothers and sisters to His glorified humanity, but we will never share His deity.

The three Persons are one in essence. That divine essence consists of attributes including sovereignty, righteousness, justice, immutability, eternal life, love, omnipotence, omniscience, and omnipresence.

God is just and justified in every judgment. At the great white throne, humanity's opportunity to speak and choose will have ended. Christ said His words will judge in the last day. Those absent from the Book of Life will learn the hour of their visitation and why judgment is righteous.

God is immutable. Neither devil, flesh, world, nor human will can alter Him. There is no shadow of turning. He is the same yesterday, today, and forever.

That is why faith is possible. What He said a thousand years ago remains as binding now as when He spoke it. Once you believe, His own character obligates Him to fulfill His Word.

When a person dies despite prayer, people may say God had a mysterious purpose. But if someone was only temporarily open to salvation and would later return to sin, I would rather see him enter heaven than recover and be lost. God did not withhold healing to teach him; He received him when healing could not be appropriated.

Learning God's attributes opened His character to me. I began seeing the lengths to which He went under every dispensation so people could know Him.

God first made me assimilate our covenant of sonship and inheritance before opening the Old Testament. I asked why He waited.

He answered, "You would have misused spiritually dead examples as many others have. Praying in tongues protected you."

Research has indicated that tongues activates a part of the brain associated with increased immune response. I can testify that in twenty-seven years of preaching I have never missed an engagement because of sickness.

For two and a half or three years, God also brought my mind out from under pressure. Temporary pressure can make a person forget his own name or fail to find a license in his hand. Imagine the long-term effect. Conversely, a mind bathed in peace affects the body for good. Once pressure lifted, my mind began healing.

God told me to trace the lives from Adam through Noah and learn how long successive generations preached.

Cain killed Abel, entered the land of Nod, and produced a line including Enoch, Irad, Mehujael, Methusael, Lamech, Jabal, Jubal, Tubal-cain, and Naamah. With Seth, men again began calling upon God.

Seth lived 912 years; Enos, 905; Cainan, 910; Mahalaleel, 895; Jared, 962; Enoch, 365 before God took him; Methuselah, 969; and Lamech, 777. Methuselah lived until the year of the Flood. Noah lived 950 years and had Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

After the Flood came Arphaxad, Salah, Eber, Peleg, Reu, Serug, Nahor, Terah, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Noah lived fifty-eight years into Abraham's life, while Shem lived into Isaac's generation. Job, from another branch of Shem's family, lived around Abraham's era and knew his Redeemer would one day stand upon the earth.

Noah taught sacrifice from the clean animals preserved by sevens. His descendants could sit at his feet and hear the Gospel transmitted across centuries.

Seeing this continuity revealed God's tender mercy. Understanding what governs His character strengthened faith and trust until I knew there was nowhere I could be placed where I could not believe Him.

At Jacob's well, Jesus told the Samaritan woman:

The hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth: for the Father seeketh such to worship him.

"The hour now is" means no such hour had existed since Adam's spiritual death. The lowercase word *spirit* properly refers to the human spirit. God is Spirit, and what He seeks can be given only from a spirit possessing His nature.

Most spiritual operations minister to us. Tongues ministers to the spirit. Fasting brings the flesh into subjection. Speaking the Word confronts troubled circumstances. Angels minister covenant benefits. Even our labor is enabled by Him.

There is relatively little we can give God that directly ministers to Him. Worship from the born-again nature does.

The Father was not seeking a better worship team from church to church. He waited through four thousand years of spiritually dead humanity while redemption moved toward the cross. Old Covenant saints worshiped through soul and mind as far as they could, while the Spirit rested upon them for particular purposes. But animal blood could not remove sin consciousness or create the new nature.

In Israel, I walked through an ancient gate Abraham would have used. The Holy Spirit said, "Your born-again experience is not merely accounted righteousness."

I nearly melted. Abraham was counted righteous, but I have been born again.

The disciples rejoiced that demons submitted in Jesus' name. Jesus redirected them to the greater fact that their names were written in heaven. He created and redeemed us for fellowship. If God could be said to have a weakness, it would be His love for us. Now that we possess a nature capable of fellowship, why deny Him what He seeks?

Church attendance and outward obedience do not necessarily fulfill God's desire for personal fellowship.

The prodigal son's parable ultimately exposes the elder brother. When celebration began, he refused to enter. He told the father:

"I never transgressed your commandment, yet you never gave me a young goat. This son wasted everything in riotous living, and you killed the fatted calf."

The younger brother broke relationship and fellowship, yet within minutes of restored relationship, he entered fellowship. The elder brother never broke relationship but never enjoyed fellowship.

The father answered, "Son, you are always with me, and everything I have is yours."

The elder son's problem was that he had never known his father well enough to use what belonged to him. Religion becomes angry when the person down the street seems to receive more grace, while claiming merit from works.

Some holiness testimonies attribute car wrecks, broken bodies, and family tragedy to God: "He broke my back because that was the only way I would serve Him."

If God were going to break anyone's back to prevent sin, He would have stopped Adam on his way to the tree and spared multitudes from hell. He did not stop Adam because sovereign love would not violate human will.

God does not delight in animal sacrifice, much less the sacrifice of His Son. In Gethsemane Jesus prayed:

| If it be possible, let this cup pass from me: nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt.

If another way could have redeemed humanity, He would not have drunk the cup. There was no other way.

God cannot exist as a dictator because His nature is sovereign love. His immutability secures our eternal future. Ten billion ages from now, He will not become irritated, change His mind, and destroy His children. He remains the same.

Human individuality and choice are precious to Him. Against every pressure of hell, we may still choose to lift our hands and worship.

A year before I entered sustained worship, I attended a passion play. Costumes, acting, music, flying angels, and theatrical hell were perfect, but there was no anointing until the altar call.

Driving home, I wondered what would fill such a production with God's presence. He answered, "Go home and worship Me all night."

I saw a stone strike a pond. Ripple followed ripple until every part of the pond moved.

God explained, "As you worship, My presence first permeates your spirit, then your soul and senses, then your geographical location. Wherever you are, I will come."

Although I did not obey then, praying in tongues eventually brought me to a point where the worship limb could no longer be postponed. A breeze passed over me in church, my spirit became weightless, and I fell to the floor.

He said, "You know nothing about worship."

Because I was fasting, I asked about the fast. He replied, "Fasting cannot give you what private worship gives, and private worship cannot give what fasting gives. When people put every egg into one basket, some areas remain unreachable because they do not employ the other keys."

I realized my basket had been tongues. He answered, "Fortunately, you chose the key that unlocks revelation knowledge. That is why you are now receiving the other limbs."

God prescribed a period of private worship because He knew I would obey. I entered a soundproof room, turned off the lights, and used no music. A worship team cannot follow me everywhere.

I chose several short statements and poured my whole soul into each:

"I love You. I worship You. I glorify You."

I worshiped in English rather than tongues because I was learning to offer the soul. Whenever my mind wandered, I stopped, retrieved it, and said, "You are in the King's presence. You will show respect."

My mind may have wandered forty times during the first hour. Still I remained. Hours dragged by, with highs and lows.

"In spirit and in truth" is first positional truth. Jesus was telling the woman that the regenerated person *can* give God what Old Covenant saints could not. It does not primarily mean beginning in flesh and eventually feeling spiritual, though that experiential transition can happen.

Books had implied that if I felt nothing, my worship was not reaching God. Beyond the first familiar hour, I became painfully dry. Yet God had told me to remain.

I had reached a ceiling of flesh beyond which my own spirit had never fellowshiped with Him except when gifts of the Spirit sovereignly drew me. Feeling less did not mean I was reaching Him less. I was pressing beyond every previous experience.

Day after day, the good periods lengthened until His presence followed me everywhere. A thought toward Him brought His nearness. Nothing evil wanted to live in that atmosphere.

Some possess analytical faith: they see Scripture's logic and know it should work, yet do not know God intimately. The missing ingredient that brings such faith alive may be private worship.

God baptizes the senses in His presence until the part resisting unseen truth comes under His ascendancy. Things begin happening.

At a March meeting, everyone who came with braces or crutches left without them. Later I learned healing was resident in the geographical atmosphere produced by worship.

A cameraman had suffered chemical burns for years. His arms were wrapped each morning, and blood soaked through by evening. Compassion and God's presence came upon me. I prayed, and by the next day the wounds had dried and pink skin appeared.

While I later recovered with tea in a back room, the pastor's wife asked prayer for a thumb that had not bent in years. From habit, I lifted my hands and worshiped. God's presence rushed in, and the thumb bent under my fingers.

A sixteen-year-old boy, blind in one eye from birth, saw what happened and knelt before me. I covered his eye, worshiped, removed my hand, and he looked back at me. His parents' rejoicing could be heard for twenty or thirty minutes.

I asked God what had happened after years of operating spiritual gifts.

He said, "You touched Me with your spirit. When you touch Me with your spirit, all that I am can flow through you. Suspend your spirit in My presence for hours and you will touch Me."

This was not merely a ministry gift. It belonged to the signs following those who believe.

Second Corinthians 3 says we behold with unveiled face and are changed from glory to glory into Christ's image. Moses wore a veil, portraying spiritual death; regenerated believers may behold God through Christ without that veil.

We often remain where we are, quote that signs follow believers, and ask God to go perform miracles for us. Meanwhile, the Spirit keeps trying to guide our spirits into the truth where those miracles live.

This path is available even to fishermen along the Amazon who can barely read. Some entered worship and said it was the hardest breakthrough they had ever faced, but they continued.

After I broke through, Tim slipped under my door a page describing how heaven receives worship. It pictured a struggling church surrounded by trials and persecution, yet lifting hands to God. The Father wept as He watched.

I said, "If I had known You received worship like that, I would have begun long ago."

He answered, "No, you would not. You would not have understood. I had to command you directly."

In heaven, worship will erupt spontaneously under waves of glory. There may never again be an opportunity to give the Father what we can give Him now.

Why does worship under trial move Him? At the cost of untold human rejection, God preserves our freedom to choose. When hell builds fortifications ahead, armies surround both sides, retreat disappears, and circumstances indict God's faithfulness, we can still lift our hands and say, "I choose You. I love and glorify You."

Finances may be shattered, children lost in sin, health failing, and every appearance contrary to promise. Still we can worship. Things will not remain the same.

Hell cannot prevent personal fellowship with the One who saved us. I stand at the helm of this ship. I hold the bit in this horse's mouth. Every day, I choose.